their part in Akbar's story.

The Mirzas, writes one modern historian, were 'troublesome in their own time, and perplexing to posterity'.[16] Indeed, the effort of telling them apart seems hardly worthwhile, the whole lot of them having been painted with the broadest possible brush as the vilest possible traitors to two generations of Mughal emperors.

And yet, the Mirzas had as much claim to imperial destiny as Babur's family. Like Babur and his sons they were descended from Timur, yes, but also, more recently, from another glorious king, Sultan Husain Baiqara of Herat, who had presided over a 'golden age of art, literature, and historical writing'[17] about a century ago. The sultan's heirs in Hindustan had never ceased to chafe, it seems, at a fate that made them subservient to Babur's offspring.

'This was an old failing in the family,' writes a historian from the time.[18] Indeed, it was a Mirza who was on guard duty when Sher Shah Suri ambushed the Mughal troops in Chausa – one of Humayun's worst military defeats. A year later, it was a group of brazen Mirzas who switched sides at Kannauj, abandoning Humayun to his second humiliating debacle at the Suri king's hands. And it was the Mirzas, forgiven by Humayun and settled in a comfortable fief by his son, who joined the Uzbek revolt against Akbar with such alacrity.

As for this particular Mirza, Ibrahim Husain who now sent his proposal of peace to Akbar in Ahmedabad – he had even more reason to imagine himself in Akbar's place. Ibrahim was married to Gulrukh Begum, Akbar's cousin and daughter of his uncle Kamran. There is no reason why Ibrahim and Gulrukh might not have wanted to restore the legacy of Humayun's less fortunate brother; no reason why they should have thought that coveting the Hindustani throne was a betrayal of Akbar and not, in fact, a legitimate claim of their own. And there was no reason, therefore, for Akbar to repeat his father's mistakes: he would not hope for loyalty from Ibrahim; he would hunt for his head, instead.

The Mirza's offer of peace was rejected.

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Akbar's conquest of Gujarat was equally, even symbiotically, his defeat of